

8. The Sons of God and the Nephilim

Passage: Genesis 6:1–8 (clean text for reading along)

A note before we begin

Four verses in Genesis have produced more strange books, late-night documentaries and internet videos than any other four in the Bible. *The sons of God saw the daughters of humankind... The Nephilim were on the earth in those days.* Some of us were taught that the sons of God were the godly descendants of Seth. Some of us were taught they were fallen angels. Some of us have never heard the passage mentioned in church at all, because it is awkward.

Christians have disagreed about these verses for eighteen hundred years, sincerely, and no one here needs to pretend otherwise. This session makes a case where the evidence leans, names who disagrees, and leaves you room. What it asks is what we have asked all along: **read it the way its first hearers would have** — people who knew their neighbours' stories about gods who fathered heroes — and follow the words where the rest of the Bible takes them. And then notice what Genesis itself does with the story, which is to tell it in four verses and turn to something it cares about more.

Aim of this session

Last time, the two family trees ran down to a man named *Rest*. Today, the eight verses between the genealogy and the ark — the last thing Genesis tells us about the world before the flood.

Five movements: the text, slowly; who the sons of God were; the Nephilim, and where the giants went; how the story grew, among Israel's neighbours and in the Jewish books of Jesus' day; and the paragraph Genesis puts right after it, which is about two hearts.

Part 1 — Read it slowly

When humankind began to multiply on the face of the earth, and daughters were born to them, the sons of God saw that the daughters of humankind were beautiful. Thus they took wives for themselves from any they chose. So the LORD said, "My Spirit will not remain in humankind indefinitely, since they are mortal. They will remain for 120 more years." The Nephilim were on the earth in those days (and also after this) when the sons of God would sleep with the daughters of humankind, who gave birth to their children. They were the mighty heroes of old, the famous men. (Genesis 6:1–4)

It opens with a blessing coming true. *Began to multiply* is Genesis 1:28 — *be fruitful and multiply* — happening. Daughters are born. For one verse, the world is doing what God said.

Then three verbs you have heard before. The NET says *beautiful*; the Hebrew says **good** — *tôb*, God's word over his own work in Genesis 1. And the sentence runs: they **saw** that they were **good**, and they **took**. That is Genesis 3:6 exactly: *the woman saw that the tree was good for food... and she took*. The first time a creature saw that something was good and took it, it was fruit. Now it is people. Genesis tells the sin of heaven in the grammar of the garden.

The Bible will use those three verbs again, and look at who uses them. Pharaoh's officials *see* Sarai and she is *taken* (12:15). Shechem, "*prince of the land*," *sees* Dinah and *takes* her (34:2). King David *sees* a woman, "*very good in appearance*," and *takes* her (2 Samuel 11:2–4). After the garden it is nearly always **rulers**, taking women because they can — and Genesis 6:2 ends the same way: *from any they chose*. No one is asked.

God answers with a limit. *My Spirit will not remain in humankind forever, since they are flesh* — the Hebrew word is *’ôlām*, "forever," and it is the word of Genesis 3:22: humans *must not... take also from the tree of life and eat, and live forever*. When humans reached up for what belonged to heaven, God drew a line at *forever*. Now heaven has reached

down, and he draws the same line in the same place. (Whether the 120 years are a new limit on a lifetime or the time left before the flood, Session 7 left open; both readings are ancient.)

And then the honour roll. *They were the mighty heroes of old, the famous men.* The Hebrew is *haggibbōrîm... 'anšê haššēm* — “the warriors... **the men of the name.**” Listen to how that sounds: like a plaque in a hall of fame. Every nation around Israel had such a plaque, and Part 4 reads some of them. Genesis puts its version one verse before the LORD looks at the earth and grieves.

Notice what is not here. No one in these four verses is called tall.

Talk about it. The sons of God *saw... good... took* — Eve’s three verbs. Why might Genesis tell this story in the grammar of the garden? Where do you see *saw, good, took* at work today, and who usually does it?

Part 2 — Who are the sons of God?

Start with the Hebrew idiom, because it does most of the work. In Hebrew, “**son of __**” *usually means “one who belongs to the class __.”* A “son of a year” is a year-old lamb. “The sons of the prophets” are prophets. A “son of death” is a man who deserves to die. A “son of man” is a human being. So *bānê hā’ēlōhîm*, the sons of God, most naturally means **members of the class ‘ēlōhîm** — divine beings — the way “sons of man” means human beings.

And that is how the phrase is used everywhere else. It and its close cousins appear in eight verses of the Old Testament, and outside Genesis every one of them is in heaven: the sons of God who *present themselves before the LORD*, with Satan among them (Job 1:6; 2:1); who *shouted for joy* with the morning stars when the world was made (Job 38:7); the *heavenly beings* told to give the LORD glory (Psalm 29:1; 89:6); the *sons of the Most High* judged in God’s assembly (Psalm 82:6). The Scripture sheet prints them all.

The heavenly court

Those verses belong to a picture the Old Testament paints again and again: **God on a throne, with a court around him.** Micaiah sees “*the LORD sitting on his throne, with all the heavenly assembly standing beside him on his right and on his left,*” and hears the court discuss what to do about King Ahab (1 Kings 22:19–22). Isaiah hears, in the throne room, “*Who will go on our behalf?*” (6:8). Daniel sees “*thrones were set up... the court convened*” (7:9–10). The court has several names — the *host* (army) of heaven, the *holy ones*, the *council*, the *sons of God* — and scholars call it **the divine council**.

Three things about this court matter for Genesis 6.

- **It is not a committee God needs.** Its members are made (“*he gave the command and they came into existence,*” Psalm 148:5) and they worship (Nehemiah 9:6). God is not one vote among many. He is a king, and a king has a court.
- **Its members can go wrong.** In Psalm 82, “*God stands in the assembly of El; in the midst of the gods he renders judgment*” — he condemns them for injustice and sentences them: “*you will die like mortals.*”
- **It was the language of Israel’s neighbours, reclaimed.** At Ugarit, a Canaanite city on the Syrian coast destroyed around 1185 BCE, the clay tablets call the gods “*the sons of El*” and “*the assembly of the gods,*” and number them **the seventy sons** of El’s wife. (Genesis 10 counts seventy nations — and Deuteronomy 32:8, in the Dead Sea Scroll the NET follows, says God divided the nations “*according to the number of the heavenly assembly.*”) Israel used the same words for the court of heaven and changed what they meant: at Ugarit the sons of El were gods who ruled; in Israel they are creatures who serve and can be judged. The neighbours sheet has the Ugaritic.

Genesis’s own “**us**” belongs in this picture too — “*Let us make humankind*” (1:26), “*the man has become like one of us*” (3:22), “*let us go down*” (11:7). The rabbis heard God speaking to his court; the church fathers heard the Trinity; both readings are old. Either way, notice where the “us” speaks: at the border between heaven and earth.

Three readings

Christians and Jews have read “the sons of God” three ways.

	Heavenly beings	The line of Seth	Kings and nobles
The claim	Members of God’s court left their place and took human wives	Seth’s godly line married the women of Cain’s line	Rulers who called themselves “sons of the gods” took any woman they wanted
Oldest witnesses	<i>1 Enoch</i> (3rd c. BCE), <i>Jubilees</i> , the Dead Sea Scrolls, Philo, Josephus; Jude, 2 Peter; Justin, Irenaeus, Tertullian	Julius Africanus (c. 221), the Syriac church, then Augustine (c. 420) — the West’s standard view through Luther and Calvin	The rabbis, from the 2nd century CE (“sons of the judges”); revived by Meredith Kline (1962) and John Walton
Strongest point	It is what the phrase means everywhere else	Keeps the story about human sin, which is where 6:3 and 6:5 put it	<i>Saw—took</i> is rulers’ grammar; ancient kings did claim divine fathers
Hardest problem	How? — and Jesus says angels do not marry	“Sons of God” never means Sethites, and nothing in the text says “Cain”	The phrase never means kings, either

The Seth reading is the one many of us grew up with, and it has an honourable history — Augustine, Chrysostom, Luther and Calvin held it. It is not the oldest Christian reading: it first appears around 221, when Julius Africanus offered it “*in my opinion*” — while his own Greek Bible read “*the angels of heaven*.” But it spread for reasons that still persuade: Jesus says that in the resurrection people “*neither marry nor are given in marriage, but are like angels in heaven*” (Matthew 22:30), and it seemed impossible that spirits could father children. And it gets something profoundly right. As Luther put it, “*the flood came not because the generation of Cain was corrupt, but because the generation of the righteous... now had lapsed*” — Genesis is not blaming the flood on anyone but us.

The king reading notices something real too: the grammar of 6:2 is the grammar of Pharaoh and David, and the oldest Jewish comment on the passage — Ben Sira’s, around 180 BCE — calls the heroes of 6:4 “*the princes of old*.” The rabbis took it up for their own reasons (one of them cursed anyone who said “sons of God”), and good evangelical scholars hold it today.

But we read with the New Testament, and the New Testament knows this story. Jude and 2 Peter do not quote Genesis 6. They do something more telling: they retell it the way the Jewish books of their own day told it.

You also know that the angels who did not keep within their proper domain but abandoned their own place of residence, he has kept in eternal chains in utter darkness, locked up for the judgment of the great Day. So also Sodom and Gomorrah... since they indulged in sexual immorality and pursued unnatural desire in a way similar to these angels... (Jude 6–7)

Angels who *left their place*; kept in chains in darkness until the judgment; set beside Sodom’s going after “*other flesh*” (Jude 7, literally) *in a way similar to these angels*. Second Peter puts the same angels **immediately before Noah and the flood** (2:4–5), and 1 Peter speaks of “*spirits in prison... disobedient long ago... in the days of Noah*” (3:19–20). Every one of those details is in *1 Enoch*’s telling of Genesis 6, and a few lines later **Jude quotes 1 Enoch** word for word (vv. 14–15). Most scholars since the mid-twentieth century, evangelicals included, read Jude 6 and 2 Peter 2:4 this way, as does the NET Bible’s own study note on Genesis 6:2. Readers who hold the Seth view answer that these verses describe an earlier fall of Satan’s angels — a fair reply, but the harder reading of Jude. Even the rabbis never fully let the angels go: Nachmanides conceded that the fallen-angel reading “*fits into the language of the verse more than all other interpretations*.” As with Enoch last time, **Genesis leaves the door ajar, and the New Testament walks through it**: the sons of God were heavenly beings who left their place. The angels Jesus says do not marry are angels *in heaven*; Jude’s point is that these left. *How*, Genesis does not say — it tells us very little on purpose.

Talk about it. Which reading were you taught, if any? What would it change for you — about God, about the unseen world, about Genesis — if the sons of God really were heavenly beings who crossed a line?

Part 3 — The Nephilim, and where the giants went

The word. *Nəpīlīm* looks like it comes from *nāpal*, “to fall,” and the old guesses start there: *the fallen ones*, or *those who fall upon others*. When Jews in Alexandria translated Genesis into Greek, around 250 BCE, they wrote *gigantes* — and through the Latin that reached the King James as “*There were giants in the earth in those days.*”

But in Greek, *gigantes* did not mean “tall people.” The Giants of Greek myth were **the children of the Earth who made war on the gods of heaven**. The translators reached for their world’s name for beings who crossed the line between heaven and earth. The size came later.

Where size enters: a report the Bible calls evil. The Nephilim appear by name exactly once after the flood — in the mouths of the ten spies:

“All the people we saw there are of great stature. *We even saw the Nephilim there* (the descendants of Anak came from the Nephilim), and we seemed like grasshoppers both to ourselves and to them.” (Numbers 13:32–33)

Numbers calls this *dibbā* — a “bad,” “evil” report — and the men who gave it “*died by the plague before the LORD*” (14:36–37). (The parenthesis linking the Anakim to the Nephilim is not in the ancient Greek translation, and may be an early scribe’s explanation.) And the last clause turned out to be wrong. Forty years later a woman in Jericho told two other spies what the Canaanites had actually felt: “*We are absolutely terrified of you... we lost our courage*” (Joshua 2:9–11). The spies saw giants and felt like grasshoppers; the people of the land saw Israel and felt the same.

Follow the thread

The Bible never loses track of the giants after that. It follows them to their end.

- **The Anakim**, tall people around **Hebron** (Numbers 13:22; Deuteronomy 9:2). Caleb — the one spy besides Joshua who did not bring the evil report — asks for their city at eighty-five: “*assuming the LORD is with me, I will conquer them*” (Joshua 14:12).
- **The Rephaim**, Deuteronomy’s name for the old tall peoples of the land — “*the Moabites call them Emites... the Ammonites call them Zamzummities*” (Deuteronomy 2:10–11, 20–21). “*Only King Og of Bashan was left of the remaining Rephaites*” — with his famous iron “bed,” thirteen and a half feet long (3:11).
- **Gath**. The last Anakim “*remained in Gaza, Gath, and Ashdod*” (Joshua 11:22). Goliath is “*from Gath*” (1 Samuel 17:4). And 2 Samuel 21 lists four more giants of Gath, “*descendants of Rapha*,” one with six fingers on each hand — “*killed by David and his soldiers.*”

After David, the giants are gone from the story. The thread that started in Genesis 6 ends with a shepherd boy and his men.

How tall was Goliath? Your Bible may differ, and both are honest. The traditional Hebrew text says “*six cubits and a span*” — about nine and a half feet (KJV, NIV, ESV). A Dead Sea Scroll copy of Samuel, the Greek Bible and Josephus say “*four cubits and a span*” — about six foot nine — and the NET follows them: “*close to seven feet tall.*” Either way, he was a giant to the men who had to face him.

Og, the last of the Rephaim

Here archaeology does something striking. The Hebrew word *rəpā’îm* has a **second meaning**: it is also the Bible’s word for **the dead** — the shades in Sheol. “*It rouses the spirits of the dead (rəpā’îm) for you, all the former leaders of the earth*” (Isaiah 14:9). Why would one word mean both a giant people and the ghosts of kings?

The tablets from **Ugarit** answer it. There the *rpum* are **the royal dead** — deified ancestors, summoned in the liturgy for a king’s funeral. Two Phoenician kings of Sidon (c. 500 BCE) had curses carved on their stone coffins against grave-robbers: “*may they have no resting-place with the Shades*” — the word is *rp’m*, **Rephaim**. And one Ugaritic tablet blesses

Rapi'u, “the eternal king,” “*the god who dwells in 'Attarat, the god who rules in Hdr'y.*” Now read Joshua 12:4: Og “*lived in Ashtaroth and Edrei.*” If those are the same two towns — many scholars think so, others read the line as divine names — then Og’s cities were where the Canaanites enthroned the king of the dead.

And Og’s land of Bashan, the Golan today, is covered with **about five thousand dolmens** — great stone tables of basalt, prehistoric tombs, found almost nowhere west of the Jordan. His “iron bed,” which the NET calls a *sarcophagus*, may have been a basalt coffin (Arabs east of the Jordan still called basalt *iron* in the 1890s), or one of those dolmens, or a relic bed overlaid with iron. To an Israelite, Og was the last king of a legendary race whose ghosts ruled below, in a land that looked like a graveyard of giants. (The neighbours sheet has the texts.)

“Were there really giants?”

It is a fair question, and the ancient world thought it had evidence. An Egyptian scribe of Ramesses II’s day, mocking a colleague who did not know the roads of Canaan, warns of Shasu nomads in a mountain pass, “*some of them... of four cubits or of five cubits, from head to foot, fierce of face*” (Papyrus Anastasi I) — seven or eight feet. People saw **enormous walls** they could not imagine men building: at Gath, Goliath’s city, the Philistine walls were four metres thick, of stones one to two metres long, and they stood in ruins for centuries — the excavator thinks they helped the giant stories along. And they found **enormous bones**. Josephus says the giants’ bones at Hebron were “*still shewn to this very day*”; the emperor Augustus decorated his villa on Capri with “*the monstrous bones of huge sea monsters and wild beasts, called the ‘bones of the giants’*”; Augustine saw “*on the shore at Utica a man’s molar tooth of such a size, that if it were cut down into teeth such as we have, a hundred, I fancy, could have been made out of it.*” We now know these were the fossils of mammoths and other great animals, and ancient people read them the only way they could. (The photographs of giant skeletons you may have seen online began as a 2002 Photoshop-contest entry built on a picture of a **mastodon** dig; *National Geographic* traced the hoax in 2007.)

So what does the Bible actually claim? **Soberly: that there were very tall warrior peoples in Canaan, remembered as the heirs of an older legend — and that they fell.** To a man of eighty-five, and to a boy with a sling.

And how did Nephilim survive the flood? The rabbis said **Og** did. One Aramaic translation makes him “*the one who escaped*” of Genesis 14:13 — “*Og... who had been spared from the giants that died in the deluge, and had ridden protected upon the top of the ark*” — and an eighth-century midrash tells it like a folk tale: Og “*sat down on a piece of wood under the gutter of the ark,*” swore to be Noah’s servant, and Noah “*bored an aperture in the ark, and he put (through it) his food daily for him.*” Others read “*and also after this*” (6:4) to mean the sons of God did it again. Others notice that the only post-flood witness is the evil report: the spies reached for the most frightening word they knew, the way we might call a big man *a Goliath*. Genesis does not say, and you may hold any of these.

Talk about it. The ten spies saw the giants and felt like grasshoppers. Caleb saw the same giants and asked for their city. What made the difference — and what are the “giants” that make you feel like a grasshopper?

Part 4 — How the story grew

The neighbours’ honour roll

The mighty heroes of old, the men of the name. To Israel’s first hearers, that line described a whole shelf of famous stories, because **in the ancient world, a divine parent was how you explained a hero.**

Gilgamesh, the most famous hero of Mesopotamia, was a king of Uruk after the flood — “*Two-thirds of him are divine,*” says the epic — and the Sumerian King List calls his father a *lillu*, a phantom. A copy found at Ugarit makes him **eleven cubits tall**. The epic opens with his people crying to the gods that he “*leaveth no maid to her mother... nor a spouse to a husband*”; an older tablet says the king takes the bride **first, and the bridegroom afterwards**. (Hear Genesis 6:2: *they took wives for themselves from any they chose.*) And when he sets out to kill the monster Humbaba, he says why: “*If I fall, I will establish my name.*” **A man of the name.**

The Greeks told it too. The poet **Hesiod**, around 700 BCE, remembers “a god-like race of hero-men who are called demi-gods, the race before our own,” destroyed by “grim war and dread battle.” And a papyrus fragment of the *Catalogue of Women*, a poem long credited to him, says that Zeus resolved “to destroy the lives of the demi-gods, that the children of the gods should not mate with wretched mortals” — and sent storm over the earth. Set that beside Genesis 6:3. In both, the high God draws a line so that heaven and earth stop mixing. (The difference is as plain: Zeus wants the gods left apart; the LORD, two verses later, grieves.)

Where the nations saw the founders of their cities and the fathers of their kings, **Genesis sees the last straw before the flood.** It keeps the plaque and hangs it on the wall of a house about to be washed away.

The Watchers

In the centuries before Jesus, Jews told the Genesis 6 story at length. The oldest version is the “**Book of the Watchers**,” the first part of **1 Enoch**, written in Aramaic in the third century BCE — the book Jude quotes. The angels are called **Watchers**, from the word Daniel uses for the *holy sentinel* who came down from heaven (Daniel 4:13).

And the angels, the children of the heaven, saw and lusted after them, and said to one another: ‘Come, let us choose us wives from among the children of men and beget us children.’... And they were in all two hundred; who descended in the days of Jared on the summit of Mount Hermon, and they called it Mount Hermon, because they had sworn and bound themselves by mutual imprecations upon it. (1 Enoch 6:2, 6)

Two Hebrew puns: they came down in the days of **Jared** because *yārad* means *to come down*, and swore on **Hermon** because *hērem* means *a curse*. Hermon is the great mountain at the head of the Jordan — **Og’s mountain**, as Joshua 12:5 says. The angels take wives, and they **teach**:

And Azâzêl taught men to make swords, and knives, and shields, and breastplates, and made known to them the metals of the earth and the art of working them, and bracelets, and ornaments, and the use of antimony, and the beautifying of the eyelids... Semjâzâ taught enchantments, and root-cuttings... Barâqijâl (taught) astrology... (1 Enoch 8:1, 3)

Their children are “great giants, whose height was three thousand ells” — nearly a mile. They devour everything, then people, until “the earth laid accusation against the lawless ones.” God has the archangels **bind** the Watchers “in the darkness... till the day of their judgement,” and sets the giants against each other. And their spirits become **the evil spirits** that trouble the earth — which is where many Jews of Jesus’ day thought demons came from. Read Jude 6 and 2 Peter 2:4 again after this, and you can hear it.

Two things to notice. First, what the Watchers teach is **the Babylonian sages’ curriculum** from last session — metalwork, the arts, the signs of the sky. Babylon said civilisation was a gift brought by sages from beyond; *1 Enoch* agrees that it came from beyond, and says it was **stolen goods**. Second, among the Dead Sea Scrolls is a companion work, the **Book of Giants**, and its giants have names. Two of them are **Gilgamesh** and **Hobabish** — Humbaba, the monster Gilgamesh killed (fragments 4Q203, 4Q530 and 4Q531). Jewish scribes two centuries before Christ put Mesopotamia’s greatest hero on the list of the Nephilim. They heard “the men of the name” exactly the way this session suggests the first hearers did.

What Genesis leaves out

Now set *1 Enoch*’s thirty chapters beside Genesis’s four verses. Genesis gives the sons of God **no names, no leader, no mountain, no oath, no teaching, no size, no punishment and no demons**. It tells one sentence of what they did, one sentence of what God said, one sentence of who their children were — and then it turns, in verse 5, to *humankind*.

That is the deepest difference. **1 Enoch explains the world’s evil as something done to humanity from above**: angels came down, seduced, taught, corrupted. **Genesis will not let that be the explanation.** Its verdict (6:3) falls on *humankind*, its diagnosis (6:5) on *the human heart*. The New Testament uses that story; Genesis refuses to make it an excuse.

(Both traditions later backed away from the angels — the rabbis in the second century, setting the Enoch books aside just as Christians were taking them up, and making the sons of God “*sons of the judges*”; the church from the third, as the Seth reading spread and Augustine ruled the Enoch books out of Scripture. The rabbinic and church sheets have both.)

Talk about it. *1 Enoch* says evil came down on us from outside; Genesis says it grew in our own hearts. Which explanation do we reach for when something goes wrong — in the world, or in us? Why is the first so attractive?

Part 5 — Two hearts

But the LORD saw that the wickedness of humankind had become great on the earth. Every inclination of the thoughts of their minds was only evil all the time. The LORD regretted that he had made humankind on the earth, and he was highly offended. So the LORD said, “I will wipe humankind, whom I have created, from the face of the earth—everything from humankind to animals, including creatures that move on the ground and birds of the air, for I regret that I have made them.” But Noah found favor in the sight of the LORD. (Genesis 6:5–8)

Count who has been seeing. God saw all that he had made — and it was very good (1:31). The sons of God saw that the daughters of humankind were good, and took (6:2). The LORD saw that the wickedness of humankind had become great (6:5). Three looks at the same world.

The human heart. The NET’s *minds* is the Hebrew *heart* — where you think and choose, not only where you feel. And *inclination* is *yēšer*, a noun from the potter’s verb of Genesis 2:7, “the LORD God **formed** the man.” The creature God formed is now forming things of its own, and every shape it makes is *only evil, all the day*. The rabbis built their teaching of the *yēšer hāra’*, the evil inclination, on this verse.

God’s heart. Verse 6 ends on the same word as verse 5: *his heart*. The NET’s *he was highly offended* hides the verb. It is *wayyit’aššēb*, from **‘ešeb, pain** — *it pained him to his heart*. And now listen back:

- “With **pain** you will give birth... in **painful toil** you will eat” (3:16–17). The curse.
- “This one will bring us **comfort** from... the **painful toil** of our hands” (5:29). Lamech, naming Noah.
- “The LORD **regretted**... it **pained** him to his heart” (6:6).

Regretted and *comfort* are the same Hebrew verb, *niḥam*. Lamech hoped his son would bring *comfort* from the *pain* of the cursed ground. The next time Genesis uses both words, **the one feeling them is God**. The pain the curse laid on the woman and the man, God takes into his own heart. Isaiah says it of Israel in the wilderness — “*they rebelled and **grieved** his Holy Spirit*” (63:10, the same root) — and Paul echoes Isaiah: “*do not grieve the Holy Spirit of God*” (Ephesians 4:30).

Can God regret? First Samuel 15 answers with both hands. “*I regret that I have made Saul king*,” says the LORD (15:11); “*the Preeminent One of Israel does not... change his mind, for he is not a human being*” (15:29); and “*the LORD regretted that he had made Saul king*” (15:35). The same chapter holds both on purpose: God does not waver the way we do, and God is not unmoved. A second-century rabbi was asked the sharp form of the question — *if God knows the future, how can Scripture say he was grieved?* — and answered with a question of his own: when your son was born, did you rejoice? “*But did you not know that he would ultimately die?*” The answer came back: “*At a time of rejoicing there is rejoicing; at a time of mourning there is mourning.*” A later rabbi finished the thought: “*Seven days the Holy One blessed be He mourned His world before the Flood*” — and proved it from the same verb used when David wept for Absalom: “*The king is **grieved** over his son*” (2 Samuel 19:2). The grief of Genesis 6:6 is **a father’s grief over a son** (Genesis Rabbah 27:4).

Wiped from the ground. *I will wipe* is the verb for wiping a dish. The *’ādām* taken from the *’ādāmâ* is to be wiped off the face of it, and the list — humans, animals, creeping things, birds — runs backward through the days of Genesis 1. This is creation being taken down.

“But Noah.” In Hebrew, *Noah* is two letters, נח, and *favor* — *hēn* — is the same two letters reversed, חנ. And this is **the first time the word *grace* appears in the Bible**. Notice the order. Verse 8: *Noah found grace*. Only verse 9: *Noah was a godly man... he walked with God*. The first time Scripture names grace, it comes before anything is said about the man who receives it. The rabbis saw it: “even Noah... it is not that he was worthy, but rather that he found favor” (*Genesis Rabbah* 28:9). Hebrews reads Noah the same way: he “became an heir of the righteousness that comes by faith” (11:7).

Then verse 9 begins a new heading and tells why the flood came a second time, in other words — *God* rather than *the LORD*, *violence* rather than the *heart*. That doubled telling is where Session 9 begins.

So what?

1. Genesis will not let the monsters take the blame. It tells its neighbours’ most glorious story — gods fathering heroes, the men of the name — in four verses, and then puts the problem where it belongs: *every inclination of the human heart*. The later books made the flood the angels’ fault. Genesis made it ours.

2. The line between heaven and earth is God’s to cross — and he crosses it the other way. In Genesis 6, beings from heaven come down and *take*; their children are heroes *of the name*. In the Gospel, “God sent out his Son, **born of a woman**” (Galatians 4:4) — heaven comes down not to take a wife but to be born of one — “to all who have received him... he has given the right to become God’s children” (John 1:12). And the one who “did not regard equality with God as something to be grasped” is the one God “gave the name that is above every name” (Philippians 2:6, 9). (*That line of thought is ours; the texts are the Bible’s.*)

3. The first thing God feels about a world gone wrong is pain. Not irritation, not surprise — ‘*eṣeb*, the pain word of the curse, *to his heart*. Judgment in Genesis comes from a God who hurts.

4. Grace is named before righteousness. The first time the Bible says *favor*, the man who finds it has not yet been described.

Talk about it — to close. *First*: Genesis 6:6 says human evil *pained* God to his heart. Does it change how you think about your own sin to hear it described as something that hurts God rather than something that angers him? *Second, this week*: notice one moment when you *see, judge good, and take* — something, someone’s time, the last word. Name it, and leave it.
